

Though your baby could survive in the outside world with assistance if born now, the uterus is still the best place for him as his lungs and digestive system mature and the brain continues to develop.

29 WEEKS You may start to feel sharp kicks from your baby.



Baby watch

15% in (39.9 cm) **3 lb (1.3 kg)**
Your baby makes practice breathing movements as he swallows amniotic fluid. His nervous system is becoming more complex, refining his movements and developing his sucking reflex. He starts to fill out more as muscle and fat are laid down. Between now and the end of pregnancy, his weight will double.

Mom matters

Your lung capacity has increased and your ribs have spread out sideways to help your lungs work harder. There is pressure on your other organs; you may find symptoms such as heartburn, constipation, and palpitations worsen, and you experience twinges, aches, and pains.

This week...

» You will be offered the whooping cough vaccine to protect your unborn baby from this virus.

» If it's hard to stay comfortable at night, position pillows to support your belly. V-shaped pillows are helpful.

30 WEEKS Review your birth plan around now. It's not too late to make changes.



Baby watch

16% in (41.1 cm) **3 lb 3 oz (1.5 kg)**
The skin is developing a pinker hue as fat builds up underneath and your baby will now be able to regulate his own body temperature. Although he is increasingly cramped for space, your baby is very flexible and can easily bring his feet up to his head, and even suck on his toes!

Mom matters

Although labor is a couple of months off, your uterus is preparing for the event by making practice "Braxton Hicks" contractions—you may start to notice tightening sensations around your abdomen around now or in later weeks. These range from being mild to a stronger cramp like feeling, but their irregularity and the fact they aren't very painful means this isn't the real thing.

This week...

» Childbirth classes start around this time.

Encourage your partner to attend so he knows what to expect. It's the perfect chance to start building a support network.

» Monitor swollen hands and feet.

31 WEEKS Your baby may be lying in any number of positions.



Baby watch

16% in (42.4 cm) **3 lb 10 oz (1.7 kg)**
As your baby exercises his limbs, his muscle mass increases and muscle tone improves, so his movements become stronger and more purposeful. His practice breathing movements are regular and rhythmic, moving his diaphragm and chest wall.

Mom matters

Your blood volume peaks around this time. This extra volume is largely due to an increase in the plasma and fluid content of the blood, while the number of red blood cells remains the same. This means the red blood cells become less concentrated, a common cause of anemia in late pregnancy. There's no need to worry about the baby, though, since he will still receive all the nutrients and oxygen he needs to thrive.

This week...

» You may have a routine prenatal appointment where your blood pressure and urine are checked, and your uterus will be measured. You will also be checked for signs of preeclampsia.

32 WEEKS Now is a good time to start thinking about practical preparations.



Baby watch

17% in (43.7 cm) **4 lb 3½ oz (1.9 kg)**
Fine tuning is taking place in your baby's nervous system as brain cells are gradually coded into distinct areas that will control specific functions. Your baby will now be looking more substantial and plump as the wrinkles start filling out.

Mom matters

The size of your belly puts pressure on your veins; this can lead to varicose veins. Gentle exercise, rest, and support hose can bring relief, and symptoms should settle down after the birth. Your belly button may pop out around now. If this bothers you, rest assured that it should go back after the birth.

This week...

» Spend time on all fours, sitting on an exercise ball, or leaning over a bean bag or ball to move your baby into the best position.

» Check out the route to the hospital now. Find out how long the trip is at different times of day.

» Talk to your doctor and partner about any anxieties you may have about the approaching labor.